

Grit and Honey

A village girl battles for the right to an education, overcomes caste barriers and becomes a textbook example for many through her successful business

Uttar
Pradesh

• BIHAR
MUZAFFARPUR

Jharkhand



ANITA SHOWS OFF
HER BEE-BOXES

| By Amitabh Srivastava |

Born in the backwaters of Bihar, and that too in the lower section of the caste pyramid, it was expected that Anita Kushwaha would shepherd goats, stay away from school and marry young. Her father, Janardhan Singh, a poorly-paid employee at a grocery shop, was determined to make Anita follow what girls had always been doing in Bochaha village of Bihar's Muzaffarpur district. But one person did not agree: Anita. She wanted to break the shackles. Now, at 21 and in the final year of a Bachelor course, Anita is an established honey-trader with an annual turnover of Rs 2.5 lakh. Her success story has even inspired a standalone chapter, *Anita and the Honeybees*, in an NCERT textbook.

It was hardly easy. Anita won her first battle when, as a six-year-old, a local teacher and she persuaded her parents to let her attend school. "It wasn't just our argument; my parents agreed because education till Class V was free," says Anita. Since they were incapable of meeting their daughter's schooling expenses, Anita began teaching children to pay for her education. She also took to running errands for "honeykeepers from neighbouring

villages who would visit our locality thanks to the litchi trees. That's how I learned beekeeping," Anita says. Fired by ambition and troubled by her poverty, she took to beekeeping full time. Using her savings of Rs 5,000 from tuitions and some money from her mother Rekha Devi, she set up her business in 2002, with two bee-boxes and as many queen bees. In just a few months, she had made a significant profit.

Anita was stung by bees many times and her swollen face would be an object of ridicule. But she kept going. "People would ask me if I get stung. Yes, I'd say. 'Does it hurt?' Yes, I'd say," she says. But it does not matter now. Anita's father left his job to join her business and visits other districts with the bee-boxes so as to collect honey from different sources. A pucca house has replaced their modest dwelling and Anita has gifted a motorcycle to her younger brother. Her improved social standing is reflected in the fact that her mother is now the village chief of a political party. Her success has inspired other families to take to beekeeping and, remarkably, every girl in her village goes to school now. ■